

# Federal demand for voter rolls is rejected

Judge calls Trump administration pursuit of California data a threat to democracy.

By Kevin Rector

A federal judge on Thursday dismissed a U.S. Justice Department lawsuit demanding California turn over its voter rolls, calling the request “unprecedented and illegal” and accusing the federal government of trying to “abridge the right of many Americans to cast their ballots.”

U.S. District Judge David O. Carter, a Clinton appointee based in Santa Ana, questioned the Justice Department’s motivations and called its lawsuit demanding voter data from California Secretary of State Shirley Weber not just an overreach into state-run elections, but a threat to American democracy.

“The centralization of this information by the federal government would have a chilling effect on voter registration which would inevitably lead to decreasing voter turnout as voters fear that their information is being used for some inappropriate or unlawful purpose,” Carter wrote. “This risk threatens the right to vote which is the cornerstone of American democracy.”

Carter wrote that the “taking of democracy does not occur in one fell swoop; it is chipped away piece by piece until there is nothing left,” and that the Justice Department’s lawsuit was “one of these cuts that imperils all Americans.”

The Justice Department did not immediately respond to a request for comment late Thursday.

In a video she posted to the social media platform X earlier Thursday, Assistant Atty. Gen. Harmeet Dhillon — who heads the Justice Department’s Civil Rights Division — said she was proud of her office’s efforts to “clean up the voter rolls nationally,” including by suing states for their data.

“We are going to touch every single state and finish this project,” she said.

Weber, who is California’s top elections official, said in a written statement that she is “entrusted with ensuring that California’s state election laws are enforced — including state laws that protect the privacy of California’s data.”

“I will continue to uphold my promise to Californians to protect our democracy, and I will continue to challenge this administration’s disregard for the rule of law and our right to vote,” Weber said.

Gov. Gavin Newsom’s office called the decision another example of President “Trump and his administration losing to California” — one day after another court upheld California’s congressional redistricting plan under Proposition 50, which the Trump administration also challenged in court af-

[See **Voter rolls**, A7]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

**JAIMMY RAY CLARK**, 57, who was homeless in June, eats a meal on Skid Row.

# Fighting homelessness fizzles into war of words

Years of litigation with city of L.A. devolve into dispute over what it means to offer a shelter bed

By Doug Smith

If a bed in a homeless shelter has been taken, is that bed still “available?”

The plaintiffs in a five-year-old lawsuit alleging the city of Los Angeles failed to address homelessness say the answer is an obvious “no.” But the city begs to differ.

According to the testimony of City Administrative Officer Matt Szabo, a bed created by the city remains “on offer” whether someone is sleeping in it or not.

That contention is one of several at the core of a hear-

ing in Los Angeles federal court to determine if the city should be held in contempt for failing to comply with a settlement, signed more than 3½ years ago, that requires it to produce more than 12,000 beds of shelter or housing and remove nearly 10,000 homeless encampments from the street.

U.S. District Court Judge David O. Carter kicked off the hearing in November with a searing review of the city’s “pattern of defiance of settlement agreement and the deadlines contained

within it with performance or performative compliance only resulting in the wake of court hearings.”

Four days of testimony, spread over nearly two months, produced a striking record of confusion and disagreement over the meaning of basic terms such as “homeless encampment” and “persons served,” leaving the impression of a city that skews definitions when it can’t live up to the common ones.

If an outreach worker

[See **Homelessness**, A9]

# In green California, plastic recycling is in the dumps

By Susanne Rust

California touts itself as a leader on the problem of plastic garbage, but recent developments suggest otherwise.

A new report issued by the state’s waste agency shows plastic yogurt containers, shampoo bottles and restaurant takeout trays are being recycled at rates only in the single digits.

Polypropylene, labeled #5 on packaging, is used for yogurt containers, margarine tubs and microwavable trays. Only 2% of it is getting recycled. Colored shampoo and detergent bottles, made from polyethylene, or #1 plastic, are getting recycled at a rate of just 5%.

Other plastics, including ones promoted as highly recyclable, such as clear polyethylene bottles, which hold

[See **Plastic**, A14]



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

**A NEW** report by the state’s waste agency finds that common plastics are recycled at single-digit rates.

# Second man alleges he was blinded at rally

Another protester was hit by a projectile shot by officers at anti-ICE demonstration in O.C.

By Ruben Vives

Homeland Security officers who blinded a young protester by shooting a less-lethal projectile at close range in Santa Ana apparently shot a second man in the face that night, blinding him too.

Britain Rodriguez, 31, a resident of Orange County, said he was standing at the bottom of some steps with other demonstrators when federal officers above opened fire at them, hitting him in the face.

“I remember hitting the ground and feeling like my eye exploded in my head,” he said.

In a video his girlfriend shared with The Times, Rodriguez can be seen on the ground, holding his face as he screams in agony before demonstrators escort him from the area.

“I can’t see, I got shot in the eye, I can’t see,” Rodriguez says before noticing

blood on his hand. “I’m bleeding.”

Rodriguez and his girlfriend, Ale, who declined to give her last name, said the officers gave no warning before firing at them. She said she was hit in the chest with a less-lethal round but was not injured.

“That’s when I started yelling at them,” she said. “I’m like holding a sign that says, ‘Stop kidnapping my neighbors’ and a candle; I am no threat to any of [those] guys.”

She said after getting shot she heard her boyfriend screaming.

The video suggests Rodriguez was struck at the same time that 21-year-old Kaden Rummier was hit in the face. Rodriguez can be heard screaming in the background just as Rummier falls to the ground.

In a statement released by Rummier this week and read by a member of the social justice organization Dare to Struggle, which organized one of the protests that day, he said doctors found pieces of plastic and glass in his skull as well as metal in his stomach lining, and pulled a piece of plastic

[See **Demonstrator**, A7]

# Dodgers go deep again. Cue the boos

Deal with free agent Tucker renews calls for spending limit and competitive balance.

By Steve Henson

Using a playbook familiar to their front office, the Dodgers waited until the market for slugging outfielder Kyle Tucker dwindled before making him an offer short on duration but generous in dollars.

The result is the defending two-time World Series champion plugged the only hole in its lineup with another superstar — one regarded by many analysts as the prize of this free-agency class. The contract Tucker agreed to Thursday night is for \$240 million over four years, with a \$64-million signing bonus and \$30 million deferred. He also will be able to opt out of the deal after the 2027 and 2028 seasons.

It’s a major development that caused immediate con-

sternation throughout baseball. The Dodgers are in a league of their own when it comes to spending on payroll.

Or as ESPN analyst Jeff Passan put it: “Fans feel like this game is unfair.”

To which Times columnist Bill Plaschke wrote, “So what? Who cares? If three consecutive titles blows up the game, so be it. The Dodgers’ only responsibility is to their fans, and they have more than fulfilled their civic duty, and that’s all that matters.”

Projections early in the offseason put offers for Tucker at around \$400 million over 10 years, but the only team that reportedly entertained a deal that long was the Toronto Blue Jays. The New York Mets made an

[See **Baseball**, A14]

**Tucker a Dodger? Of course he is**

The champions can’t be stopped, Bill Plaschke writes. **SPORTS, B12**

# In China, a new app offers proof of life

As more young people live solo in far-flung locations, ‘Are You Dead?’ meets a need.

By Ted Anthony and Fu Ting

BEIJING — In China, the names of things are often either ornately poetic or jarringly direct. A new, wildly popular app among young Chinese people is definitively the latter.

It’s called, simply, “Are You Dead?”

In a vast country whose young people are increasingly on the move, the new, one-button app — which has taken the country by digital storm this month — is essentially exactly what it says it is. People who live alone in far-off cities and may be at risk — or just perceived as such by friends or relatives — can push an outsize green circle on their phone screens

and send proof of life over the network to a friend or loved one. The cost: about \$110.

It’s simple and straightforward — essentially a 21st century Chinese digital version of those American pendants with an alert button on them for senior citizens that gave birth to the famed TV commercial: “I’ve fallen, and I can’t get up!”

Developed by three young people in their 20s, “Are You Dead?” became the most downloaded paid app on the Apple App Store in China last week, according to local media reports. It is also becoming a top download in places as diverse as Singapore and the Netherlands, Britain and India and the United States — in line with the developers’ attitude that loneliness and safety aren’t just Chinese issues.

“Every country has young people who move to big cities to chase their dreams,” Ian Lü, 29, one of

[See **App**, A4]



Getty Images

**A FOOD VENDOR** at a Tehran market on Friday.

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## Iranian cleric threatens Trump

The country’s streets remain quiet as the death toll from protests nears 2,800, a U.S. group says. **WORLD, A2**

## Trading news for ministry

Longtime NBC4 journalist Ted Chen is retiring to become a full-time minister. **BUSINESS, A10**

## Weather

Partly sunny; warm. L.A. Basin: 83/56. **B8**

## Court filings name ICE agent

The off-duty officer linked to a fatal shooting in Northridge is accused of abuse and racism. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

## U.S. agencies’ extremist slogans

Nazi-esque content on official websites? Yes, that’s where we are, Anita Chabria writes. **CALIFORNIA, B1**



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